

HINDUSTAN TIMES

JUAL ORAM, *63* | BJP
Minister of Tribal Affairs

Working his way up Oram was born into a poor tribal family in a village in Odisha's Sundargarh district. With a diploma in Electrical Engineering, he worked with BHEL for six years before joining the BJP in 1989. He served as an MLA for two terms until 1998

The first minister In 1999, the six-time MP from Sundargarh was appointed the first minister in the Union tribal affairs ministry, created by PM Vajpayee, a role he was reassigned in Modi 1.0

Minister of State



DURGADAS UIKEY, *61* | BJP

Old RSS hand Beginning as a school-teacher in Madhya Pradesh, Uikey later worked with the RSS. The MP from the state's Betul constituency has been involved with the ministry previously as a member of its Consultative Committee

AGENDA NDA GOVERNMENT

TRIBAL AFFAIRS

Uplifting Tribals

The government needs to boost its commitment to the welfare of India's vast tribal communities

By SONALI ACHARJEE

Tribal upliftment has been a key focus area of the Modi government through all its terms. This perhaps explains the 190 per cent increase in budget allocation for the tribal affairs ministry in the past decade—from Rs 4,295.94 crore in FY14 to Rs 12,461.88 crore in FY24. These funds have gone towards improving education, healthcare and employment opportunities for tribal communities. It does not come as a surprise then that more than 120,000 students are currently enrolled in the flagship Eklavya Model Residential Schools set up in remote areas. Skill training and land rights initiatives for tribals have also been a priority, as is their economic empowerment—the ministry has ensured MSP for minor forest produce and marketing support for tribal products under the Janjatiya Vikas Mission, which has 183,412 tribal persons associated with it. PM Modi launched the Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan last year. Allocated a budget of around Rs 24,000 crore, it is intended for the development of Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups. Seventy-five such groups, numbering some 2.8 million, live in 22,544 villages across 18 states and UTs. The aim is to ensure basic facilities like road, telecom, electricity, safe housing, sanitation and clean drinking water for even scattered tribes staying in remote and inaccessible habitations and bring relief to even the poorest of the poor. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

TRIBAL LAND AND RESOURCE RIGHTS While there are laws to protect tribal rights, both their implementation and people's access to them need to be improved

IMPROVING EDUCATION STANDARDS Apart from expanding the number of schools in tribal areas, there is a need for more learning materials and sanitary provisions. Also, classes need to be taught in indigenous languages

PROTECTING TRIBAL IDENTITY With rapid urbanisation, it is imperative to preserve tribal culture and identity and ensure that non-tribal populations respect the dignity of tribal culture

REHABILITATION For those who might have lost their land to development, the programmes for resettlement must be enforced with sensitivity, not just with regard to the logistics but also bearing in mind the psychological impact of displacement